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Direct all trade enquiries to General Manager (Sales), Living Media India Limited,

201 Competent House, F-14, Middle Circle, Connaught Place, New Delhi • Regd.

Office: K-9 Connaught Circus, New Delhi 110001 • Impact Offices: Trade Centre,

2nd Floor, Kamala City, Senapati Bapat Marg, Lower Parel, Mumbai 400013;

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Delhi 110001; Phone: 23352233; Fax: 23327330 • 98-A, Dr. Radhakrishnan Salai,

2nd Floor, Mylapore, Chennai-600 004; Phones: 28478526-41; Telex: 041-6177

Info In; Fax: 28472178; Cable: Livmedia Chennai • 201-204 Richmond

Towers, 2nd Floor, 12, Richmond Road, Bangalore-560025; Phones: 22212448,

22213037, 22218343; Fax: 22218335; Cable: Livmedia, Bangalore • 52,

Jawaharalal Nehru Road, 4th Floor, Kolkata-700071; Phones: 22825399;

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Hyderabad-500082; Phone: 23401657, 23400479, 23410100, 23402481,

23410982, 23411498; Fax: 23403484 • 39/1045, Karakkatt Road, Kochi 682016;

Phones: 2377057, 2377058; Fax: 2377059 • 2/C, 'Suryaraj Bldg', 2nd Floor,

Behind White House, Panchwati, Office C.G. Road, Ahmedabad-380006;

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From the editor-in-chief

It's normally difficult to capture the essence of a whole year in one headline. Life doesn't happen in neat packages for journalistic convenience.

However, 2008 was different. Many good things happened in that year: India displayed the cheapest car in the world; we won our first individual Olympic gold; an Indian author won the Booker prize; the IPL was a grand success; we launched a spacecraft to the moon; a historic nuclear deal was signed against heavy odds. And the world witnessed the amazing rise of a new leader of great promise in the world's most powerful nation, a man who has aptly been described as "a leader born in the imagination".

But this was all overshadowed by two major phenomena which struck at the core of every human being's main concerns—their life and financial security. Terror and the economic meltdown affected all our lives. It was, therefore, with some sadness we termed 2008 as the 'Year of Fear'.

The year saw six of our major cities hit by as many as nine terrorist attacks putting India through a cycle of violence and death. Terrorism and insurgency claimed the lives of nearly 1,600 people across the country in 2008. As always, Indians picked themselves up with courage and resolve, but the audacious Mumbai attack created an angry backlash against the political and bureaucratic class which governs us and whose job is to keep

us safe from enemies within and without. It exposed to us and to the world how rotten our governance and administration have become.

The bedrock of the feel-good India story, our economy, is now suffering the effects of the global financial crisis. Inflation touched double digits in 2008 before subsiding a few percentage points, the stock exchange hit its highest and its lowest in five years and one

million jobs were lost. After hitting 9 per cent growth last year, growth for 2008 may dip down to 7 per cent by some estimates with no one willing to place any bets on the figures for the next financial year.

These twin forces which ruined 2008 for us are still at work and there remains a sense of insecurity in the air. The fact that we stand on the brink of an armed conflict with our neighbour doesn't help matters either.

Nevertheless, our year-end issue is a lookback at 2008 in the best of words and pictures. Along with essays that track the trends in politics, business, diplomacy, entertainment and sport, we have reintroduced the very popular Reporter's Diary. Our correspondents from across the country bring you a behind-the-scenes look at some of the biggest stories of the year—whether it was the Mumbai attack, the floods in Bihar or the Olympic Games in Beijing.

Fortunately, history doesn't move in a straight line, it tends to be cyclical. We've seen meltdowns and terror attacks in the past and as grandmothers are prone to saying: 'This too, my son, shall pass'. And so it will. For me, the greatest legacy of 2008 is the catchphrase 'Be the Change'. That's what I intend to be and maybe you should too. On that happy note, I wish you a very happy, peaceful and prosperous New Year.

(Aroon Purie)



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